Representing Depression in Social Media: Content Analysis of Mental Support Posts on Weibo in China

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Abstract. Depression remains a significant mental health challenge in China, where stigma and cultural concerns about depression often discourage open discussion. Weibo, one of the most popular content-sharing platforms in China, have become an important space for sharing individual experiences and seeking support. Yet, little is known about how different forms of support are exchanged in the quasi-public sphere. This study analysed 150 top-ranked posts from Weibo's Depression Super Topic by using content analysis under the theoretical framework of social support theory. Posts on Weibo were coded as support-seeking or support-providing and categorised into emotional, informational, or instrumental types, with qualitative notes documenting culturally specific expression styles. The findings show that the community primarily functions as a safe space for emotional disclosure, with help-seeking far outweighing help-providing and emotional support dominating the discourse. Informational support is limited, and instrumental support is absent, highlighting potential unmet needs and platform constraints.

Keywords: Depression, Social Support, China, Weibo, social media.

1 Introduction

Depression is a major global health concern. In China, the condition affects a vast population, while stigma surrounding mental illness persists [1]. In recent years, the rapid expansion of social media, particularly among younger generations, has propelled platforms like Weibo to the forefront of mental health discourse. In Weibo groups, individuals openly share personal experiences and seek support for psychological distress.

Despite the increasing visibility of depression-related discourse online, there remains a limited understanding of how Chinese social media users narrate their experiences of depression and strategically seek social support within this culturally specific digital environment. Existing studies often focus on general mental health communication, but few offer empirical analyses of user-generated content in topic-centred online communities, such as the Weibo depression topic group. This study fills a gap through examining the top-ranked posts in the depression group on Weibo.

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2 Literature Review

2.1 Social Support Theory in Online Contexts

Scholars typically categorize social support into three types: emotional, informational, and instrumental support [2]. Emotional support usually involves empathy, understanding, and encouragement. Informational support means advice and sharing knowledge. Instrumental support refers to specific help, such as material aid.

With the rise of the Internet and social media, social support theory has been gradually introduced into the online context, suggesting that virtual spaces can also serve as a source of social support. A recent study shows that active social media use boosts individuals' perceived support and reduces loneliness and depressive symptoms during and after lockdowns [3]. While many studies have advanced the understanding of online social support, there remains limited exploration of how cultural norms shape the forms and styles of support exchanged. This gap is particularly relevant for Chinese social media platforms, such as Weibo, where distinct cultural values may influence how support is expressed, interpreted, and sought.

2.2 Cultural Perceptions of Mental Health in China

In China, stigma remains an obstacle for people with mental health issues to openly discuss and seek professional help. Concerns over the damage to personal and family reputation have further suppressed public discussion on mental health, especially on social media platforms that emphasize "face" and public image [4]. In addition, the lack of mental health literacy and limited trust in professional psychological counseling services have also weakened people's willingness to seek professional help [5]. Under the influence of multiple factors, individuals often turn to informal peer online communities, obtaining a relatively safe space for self-disclosure in anonymous and theme-distinct communities.

At the same time, cultural perceptions also profoundly influence how people seek support within communities. Chinese collectivist philosophy emphasizes group harmony and the maintenance of social networks. Therefore, emotional support is usually more popular than informational and instrumental support, while self-disclosure is often selective and indirect to avoid burdening others. However, Western individualist values place a greater emphasis on individuals, so explicit requests for advice or practical assistance are more popular [6][7].

Cultural dynamics are crucial for understanding the discourse on depression on Weibo. Because they not only influence individuals' self-disclosure but also shape the types and expressions of social support.

2.3 Social Media Studies on Depression

To assist people with depression, some scholars turn to social media platforms rich in self-disclosure on depression. By analyzing posts, researchers identify unique expressions, emotions, and behavioral patterns. In China, studies of social media posts find

that depression is often viewed as a personal issue. Posts rarely discuss specific coping methods. This may increase stigma and limit public understanding of depression. Further linguistic analyses also show that users with depression express more negative emotions and discuss sensitive topics such as self-harm or suicide risks [8][9].

Although the findings are abundant, existing works mostly focus on risk identification and language feature presentation, and rarely incorporate both social support theories and cultural perspectives into their analytical frameworks simultaneously. Therefore, to fill this gap, it is necessary to conduct a systematic empirical analysis that captures both the thematic and linguistic dimensions of online discourse, enabling a deeper understanding of how cultural context influences support-seeking and support-providing behaviors in Chinese social media platforms.

2.4 Identified Research Gaps and Research Questions

Existing scholarly results have shown that depression is often attributed to individual-level factors. However, posts are rarely classified simultaneously by type of social support. Accordingly, this study addresses the following research questions:

RQ1: In the Depression Super Topic on Weibo, what thematic categories emerge from user posts, and what proportion are related to social support?

RQ2: In support-seeking posts, what is the distribution of emotional, informational, and instrumental support requests? Which type is most common, and what are its typical expressions among them?

RQ3: In support-providing posts, what is the distribution of emotional, informational, and instrumental support offered? Which type is most common, and what are its typical expressions among them?

RQ4: How do Chinese cultural factors influence the style, audience targeting, and alignment between sought and provided support?

3 Method

3.1 Research Design

This study employed content analysis to examine both support-seeking and support-providing expressions related to depression on Weibo. The coding framework distinguishes three primary support types: emotional, informational, and instrumental. Posts are coded as seeking support or providing support, and then categorized according to the type of support required, which aims to identify the most common support types in each mode.

In addition, the research also captured culturally specific features through qualitative notes, which may influence the style and frequency of seeking support or providing support on Weibo. This mixed method not only provides descriptive statistical analysis but also achieves context-sensitive cultural analysis, which aligns with previous findings on online mental health discourse.

3.2 Data Collection

The dataset was collected from the Depression Super Topic on Weibo, which is the largest discussion group focused on depression, with approximately 300,000 members. It also ranks second among all medical-related "Super Topics" on Weibo, making it a key site for peer-to-peer mental health interaction. This community was selected due to its large and active membership, as well as its focus on depression, making it a rich source for authentic, naturally occurring expressions of support-seeking and support-providing.

To ensure visibility, this study selected the top 150 most popular posts ranked by Weibo's "hot posts" algorithm in the Depression Super Topic. These tweets represent widely viewed and engaged content within the community and are believed to reflect influential discourse patterns and shared norms. This constitutes purposive sampling, targeting posts most likely to shape community interaction.

3.3 Coding and Analysis

The unit of analysis was a single post published in the depression-themed Super Topic. All posts were classified into seven mutually exclusive categories, adapted from social support theory and tailored to the context of depression. Detailed definitions and translated examples for each category are provided in Table 1.

Table 1. categories of themes on Weibo.

Themes	Definition	Examples(translated)
Emotional support requests	expressions of negative emotional states or appeals for empathy, reassurance, or encouragement	"I feel life is worse than death—can someone hold me?"
Informational support requests	inquiries seeking knowledge about depression, such as symptoms, medication, or treatment options	"Are there any recommended doctors for depression in Zhengzhou?"
Instrumental support requests	appeals for tangible resources or services	"My depression is getting worse, but my family can't afford treatment. What should I do?"
Emotional support provisions	expressions of empathy, validation, or encouragement directed toward others	"Don't blame yourself—it's not your fault."
Informational support provisions	offers of actionable advice, personal experiences, or resources for managing depression	"Sun exposure on your back helps—works for me every day"
Instrumental support provisions	offers of tangible resources or services, or willingness to provide them	"I recommend doctor XX at XX hospital"
Unrelated messages	posts irrelevant to depression	"Sharing my newly bought strawberries"

Two trained native-Chinese-speaking coders independently applied the coding scheme to all posts. Percentages of coding consistency were calculated to compare the prevalence of support types within and across the two interaction modes. The credibility of the analysis was ensured through coder training, dual coding, and regular reliability tests, which enhance the consistent application of the coding scheme.

4 Results

A total of 150 posts from Weibo's Depression Super Topic were coded according to the pre-defined seven-category framework derived from social support theory (three types of support requests, three types of support provisions, and unrelated content). Among them, 89 posts (59.3%) contained social support content, while 61 posts (40.7%) were unrelated or off-topic. Support-seeking posts (n = 69, 46.01% of all posts) far outnumbered support-providing posts (n = 20, 13.3%), revealing a clear asymmetry between help-seeking and help-giving behaviors.

Overall, emotional support requests were the most common type of post, accounting for nearly four in ten posts. See Table 2 for the proportion of social support requests. Instrumental support provision was entirely absent from the dataset. See Table 3 for the proportion of social support provisions. This pattern aligns with prior research, which highlights the predominance of emotional content in mental health discussions on Chinese social media.

Table 2. proportion of social support requests.

Social support requests	n	Proportion (%)	Example (translated)
Emotional	58	38.67%	"After he hit me, my depression relapsed and I couldn't stop crying…"
Informational	7	4.67%	"Does anyone in Zhengzhou have a recommended depression doctor?"
Instrumental	4	2.67%	"The medication costs 300 yuan per week… I can't afford to continue treatment."
Total	69	46.01%	/

Table 3. proportion of social support provisions.

Social support provisions	n	Proportion (%)	Example (translated)
Emotional	14	9.33%	"Don't blame yourself — we will get through this together."

Informational	6	4.00%	"Try exposing your back to sunlight for an hour a day — it can help relieve symptoms."
Instrumental	0	0%	/
Total	20	13.3%	/

4.1 Patterns in Support-Seeking Posts

In the Depression Super Topic, emotional support seeking holds an absolute dominant position (84.1% of the support-seeking posts). In contrast, the proportion of informational and instrumental support seeking is much lower. Requests for emotional support often include descriptions of pain, family conflicts, or a lack of self-worth. Requests for informational support mainly involve medical advice and treatment options; Instrumental support requests, on the other hand, focus more on obtaining specific tangible assistance, such as financial assistance or accompaniment. This distribution is consistent with the existing findings of online support communities, which show that mental health discussions, particularly those related to depression, are dominated by emotional content, whereas informational support is more common in discussions of physical health conditions.

People primarily use the Depression Super Topic to openly express feelings and seek empathy, rather than ask for practical help, which highlights the value of online communities for people with depression, especially those lacking offline support. However, the lack of informational and instrumental support seeking also reveals a gap for users in accessing actionable resources, which suggests that the platform needs to strengthen the practical support mechanism for users facing mental health challenges.

4.2 Patterns in Support-Provision Posts

Among support-providing tweets, emotional support is the most prevalent, accounting for 70 percent. Informational support accounts for 30 percent. No instrumental support appears. Emotional support means encouragement and empathy. Informational support offers personal therapy experiences and practical advice.

This distribution of support-providing types demonstrates that the community serves as a space for emotional resonance and connection among its members. The strong dominance of emotional provision shows that users' demands are primarily for emotional relief and understanding, rather than specific solutions. The complete absence of instrumental support can be attributed to two barriers. The limitations in integrating resources and providing assistance functions within the community, as well as the weakness of offline connections among members. To address this gap, supplementary support from external mental health services or formal care systems may be beneficial.

4.3 Cultural-Linguistic Features of Support Exchange

Members' communication obviously shows culturally adaptive strategies. To express

dissatisfaction with others' unhelpful suggestions, they use indirect metaphors, such as "singing to the deaf." To avoid stigma from social scrutiny, they choose to conceal illnesses. They also actively integrate traditional Chinese medicine practices, such as sun-exposure therapy, to nourish Yang energy. Sometimes, members share daily photos or festival greetings to foster community cohesion.

More crucially, people are used to employing culturally resonant idioms and metaphors to describe their emotional states, such as emphasizing endurance or concealing pain, which profoundly reflect the influence of interdependence orientation and cultural norms on mental health expression in China. These choices are not only a preference for language style, but a necessary adaptive strategy to counter the potential social risks resulting from disclosing depression, especially in cultural contexts that seldom encourage showing vulnerability in public.

4.4 Summary of Findings

Firstly, a support imbalance exists. On the one hand, emotional support is completely dominate. Community members tend to disclose feelings of distress and receive validation or encouragement, but less frequently exchange advice or practical help, which suggests that individuals may have concerns about credibility, responsibility, or the sensitivity of mental health topics. On the other hand, support-seeking far outweighs support-providing.

Secondly, there is a gap in the instrumental support. The absence of instrumental support provisions demonstrates limitations of community operation and members' potential unmet needs, which signals organizers and platforms to complement support structures, such as formal mental health services and helplines.

Thirdly, the expressions and social support of the members reflect the profound influence of cultural norms. Indirect expressions and euphemisms are particularly common in discussions because people use them to avoid potential stigma or shame in a cultural setting that discourages openly showing vulnerability.

Lastly, irrelevant posts play an important role in maintaining community engagement. These off-topic posts, involving humor, daily life, or others, serve to maintain social cohesion and user engagement, which allow members to interact outside of the heavy emotional focus of support-seeking, creating a sense of belonging and community beyond illness and further ensuring that the space remains attractive and sustainable as an ongoing peer-support network.

5 Discussion

The current study finds that social support posts in the Depression Super Topic are shaped by the Chinese cultural norms, which is consistent with recent sociolinguistic and public health research conducted in various cultural contexts [10][11]. Stigma, the pursuit of social harmony, and other cultural norms influence users' expression of distress, help-seeking and help-provision online, which suggests that effective digital men-

tal health interventions are expected to be sensitive to local discourse and cultural attitudes.

5.1 Interpretation from the Perspective of Social Support Theory

The findings from Weibo support-seeking posts can be interpreted through the lens of social support theory, which distinguishes between emotional, informational, and instrumental support. Informational support, while less frequent, remains significant and aligns with established patterns in online support groups, where mental health discussions tend to be more emotionally oriented than those for physical health conditions. However, the effectiveness of these support types is not uniform. The digital platforms may facilitate connection but often struggle to address the nuanced and complex needs of users experiencing depression. This underscores the importance of designing interventions that integrate both emotional and informational strategies to enhance the quality of online support.

5.2 Cultural Influences on Depression Representation

Cultural influences are reflected in depression representation and discussion on Weibo. Collective values and the cherish for social harmony led individuals to conceal their struggles to avoid stigma and loss of face. This also results in indirect expressions and the use of culturally resonant idioms in Weibo posts. Content analyses show people often attribute depression to individual-level factors in Chinese social media platforms, further reinforcing stigma and limiting scientific explanations or effective coping. While Western culture encourages open discussion and direct support-seeking for depression, making explicit talk and advice more common. Chinese users more often express distress through subtle cues and seek empathy rather than direct advice or intervention. These contrasting patterns underscore the importance of culturally tailored online interventions that address both linguistic and social barriers to mental health support in China.

5.3 Implications for Online Mental Health Interventions

Peer interaction, professional counseling, and culturally adopted support content are three key points of effective online mental health interventions. Combining these points together, users' emotional and informational needs can be well matched. In addition, well-trained moderators are also necessary as they need to prevent potential harm and create a safe communication space for supportive conversations. These strategies are of significance for developing scalable and effective mental health interventions in the unique cultural context of Chinese social media.

5.4 Comparison with Prior Research

Consistent with the findings of existing studies, emotional support content is indeed a

major component of the discussions related to depression on Weibo that we analyzed. However, the data from this platform also highlights how the distinct cultural features, especially the influence of stigma and collectivist values, lead to a way of seeking help and expressing sorrow that is quite different from the more common direct self-disclosure in the West.

6 Conclusion

Within the Depression Super Topic, support-seeking far outweighs support provision. The community primarily serves as a space for emotional disclosure, centered on empathy, reassurance, and identification, rather than providing information or tangible assistance. On the one hand, this aligns with relational regulation theory, which emphasizes the role of daily interactions in regulating emotional well-being. On the other hand, this highlights the platform limitations, such as the fact that members' needs for tangible assistance may not be able to be fulfilled. Expressions related to support-seeking and support provision are shaped by cultural norms. Popular indirect expressions, stigma avoidance, and traditional health beliefs are evidence. Off-topic content, although not directly supportive, plays a crucial role in maintaining engagement and social cohesion, further fostering a balanced environment that encourages continued participation and interaction.

Together, the findings highlight the Depression Super Topic as a community that prioritizes emotional validation and relational support over concrete problem-solving or resource mobilization, which emphasizes the need to supplement peer-to-peer spaces with interventions that integrate both emotional and informational strategies, ensuring that users' psychosocial and practical needs are more comprehensively addressed. Last but not least, though digital peer-support communities offer meaningful empathy and shared experience, their full potential is realized only when coupled with structured resources and guidance.

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